CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

MOTION DESIGNER / 3D ARTIST IN THE AI ERA

The six-second product spin you want to get paid for is now a text prompt — and the client already has the app.

★ TL;DR — NO — for the generalist entry. The title's own market median is ~$73–77K, and its federal proxy occupation (Special Effects Artists & Animators, BLS) medians $102,030 at 0% growth — flat. The work priced at this title's level — templates, logo idents, product spins, social loops — is precisely what Runway, Kling and Veo-class tools now generate. The roadmap below is the way OUT: take the timing-and-taste brain into rooms where the deliverable can't be prompted. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK MEDIUM

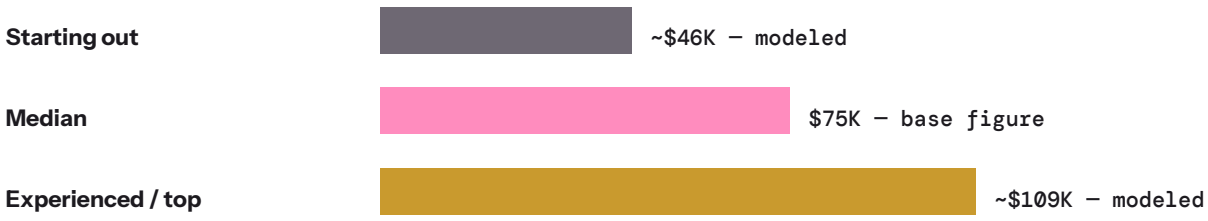
- Fails as a start because: both federal anchors are flat or falling — the 3D/VFX proxy grows 0% (BLS, 2025–35) and the 2D motion tier sits inside Graphic Designers at −2% — while generative video is productised against exactly the junior deliverable: short-form ad motion, explainers, idents, product spins.

- The exposure problem: 47% of entertainment business leaders expected generative AI to be effective at generating 3D assets within three years (Animation Guild / CVL Economics study) — and asset generation was the junior 3D artist's first paid task. Lionsgate took an equity stake in Runway; Netflix has already aired a finished AI-generated shot.

- Still worth money: timing, taste and camera judgment. The durable corners — Houdini simulation, real-time/Unreal technical art, engineering-constrained visualisation — are hired as technical artists inside the VFX/software occupations: a harder, different door than this title sells.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Motion Designer / 3D Artist is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A MOTION DESIGNER / 3D ARTIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Animate logos, ads, product videos and social content for brands and agencies
- ✓ Model, light and render 3D product shots, or build 2D motion in After Effects-class tools
- ✓ Turn a brief into styleframes and boards a client signs off on
- ✓ Deliver the same campaign in twelve sizes, formats and languages by Friday

Think: a puppeteer for brands — except the strings are now sold as a subscription, and the client is learning to pull them.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Short-form motion itself: product spins, logo idents, explainer animation, social loops, template-based ad variants — the launch demos, and increasingly the shipped product, of Runway (Gen-4), Kling and Veo-class generators.	Timing and taste that survive contact with a real product: camera moves over physical objects, motion systems a whole brand lives in, and technical art where physics and engineering constraints bite.

⚠ **THE $102K MIRAGE: the big BLS number belongs to incumbent VFX artists in film and software — a senior tier inside a 0%-growth occupation. Quoting it to sell a motion-design course is how beginners get trained for the layer the generators already took.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Visually satisfying, portfolio-driven work — your reel travels and is judged on sight ✓ Real craft: timing, easing and rhythm are genuinely learnable and genuinely rare ✓ Agencies, brands and product teams all buy motion — the question is which kind	✗ The generalist middle is being generated: templates, spins and loops are a prompt now ✗ Trend cycles are brutal — last year's style is this year's stock preset ✗ Render queues and client deadlines remain mortal enemies, AI or not

Good fit? You already shoot or edit real footage, or you think like a product designer — for you the motion craft becomes an asset on top of a growing job instead of the whole job.
Bad fit? You want to sell template-tier motion — logo stings, product spins, social loops — as a standalone living. That shelf is the generator's home turf.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Video Editor	DOOR B — PIVOT TO UX/UI Designer
BLS Film and Video Editors and Camera Operators: editor median $75,420, growth +3%, ~5,600 openings a year for the combined occupation (2025–35). The bridge is direct: you already think in cuts, timing and rhythm; editing is motion design where the raw material is footage instead of keyframes — and footage of real things can't be prompted into existence. Working editors have absorbed AI as an assistant layer (transcription, logging, rough assembly) without losing the door. First move: cut a 60-second spec ad from stock footage with your motion graphics on top — that single piece is both portfolios at once.	BLS Web Developers and Digital Designers: blended median $99,520, growth +5%, ~13,600 openings a year — and the designer line inside that occupation medians $104,000. Products run on motion now: onboarding flows, micro-interactions, loading states, design systems that move. Product teams hire motion craft as a feature of UX, not as a standalone title, and your keyframe brain is the differentiator most UI designers don't have. First move: redesign one app's onboarding as an animated prototype and write up the decisions. That's a UX portfolio piece with your unfair advantage baked in.

Smart move: If you stay technical: go where generation can't follow — Houdini simulation, real-time/Unreal technical art, product and architectural visualisation with engineering constraints. That corner is priced toward the $102K BLS tier, but it's hired as a technical artist inside VFX/software, reached with engineering-grade skills — not with a prettier reel of spins.
Where you land after: You land where the deliverable can't be generated: cutting real footage for brands and creators, or designing product experiences that move. The keyframes come with you — as the premium layer, not the whole offer.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
ADMIT THE	RE-AIM THE	BUILD ONE	LEARN THE	GET A	APPLY AS

STEP 1 — Admit the template layer is gone

FREE · TODAY

- Watch the current generator demos with a client's eyes: the spin, the ident, the loop — that's your old first job, priced at a subscription
- Your asset isn't the software list — it's timing and judgment. That's what moves

STEP 2 — Re-aim the craft at footage

FREE · 1–2 WEEKS

- Take your strongest motion piece and rebuild it around real footage — stock is fine, the cut is the skill
- Learn the editor's pipeline: ingest, logging, assembly, captions — the AI-assisted layer you'll supervise, not fear

STEP 3 — Build one dual-purpose piece

FREE · 2–3 WEEKS

- Cut a 60-second spec ad: real footage, your graphics and timing on top
- Post the breakdown — footage choice, cut points, where the motion serves the product

STEP 4 — Learn the editor's toolkit

SELF-PACED · 2–4 WEEKS

- Premiere/DaVinci-class workflow to professional speed: sound, color, delivery specs
- Keep the motion tools — as the top layer, not the foundation

STEP 5 — Get a live rep

FREE · 3–4 WEEKS

- Edit one real project for a local business, creator or agency overflow desk
- Capture proof: the finished piece, the deadline you hit, one measurable result

STEP 6 — Apply as an editor who moves

FREE · ONGOING

- Video editor and hybrid editor-motion roles; lead with the spec ad and the breakdown
- Keep Door B warm: one animated product prototype a month keeps the $99,520 door open

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: watch the generator demos, then open an editor. The second window is the career.

□ Days 1–30: editing workflow learned; first footage-based piece underway with your graphics on top.

□ Days 31–60: spec ad finished and posted with its breakdown; one real project delivered.

□ Days 61–90: applications out as an editor-motion hybrid — or one product prototype built if Door B pulls harder.

 Day 90: you're an editor with a motion unfair advantage — not a generalist waiting for template work a prompt now does.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ TIMING MOVES. TEMPLATES DON'T. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.